

IELTS Academic – Simulated Test

Total Test Time: 2 hours 45 minutes (plus Speaking)

- Listening: 40 minutes (including 10 minutes to transfer answers)
 - Reading: 60 minutes
 - Writing: 60 minutes
 - Speaking: 11–14 minutes (separate)
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General Candidate Instructions

- Read all instructions carefully.
- Write answers on the answer sheet provided.
- Do not open the question booklet until told to do so.
- Use pencil; rub out any mistakes completely.
- No dictionaries or electronic devices are allowed. Mobile phones must be switched off.

Listening

- You will hear each recording once only.
- Answer the questions as you listen.
- At the end, you will have 10 minutes to transfer your answers to the answer sheet.

Reading

- Answer all questions.
- You may write in the question booklet, but only answers on the answer sheet will be marked.

Writing

- Complete both Task 1 and Task 2.
- Task 2 is worth more marks than Task 1.
- Write clearly and organise your ideas logically.

Speaking

- The Speaking test is a face-to-face interview.
 - The examiner will guide you through the three parts.
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LISTENING SECTION

Time: 40 minutes (including 10 minutes to transfer answers)

Questions: 40 (10 per part)

You will hear four recordings. Answer all the questions.

Listening Part 1 – Social Conversation

Context: A man calls about renting a flat.

Questions 1–10

Answer in short form.

1. What is the name of the man calling?
2. How much is the monthly rent?
3. Which utilities are included in the rent?
4. How much is the deposit?
5. What is the minimum lease length?
6. Is the flat fully furnished?
7. What must the tenant bring?
8. Is parking guaranteed? (Yes/No)
9. How far is the bus stop from the flat?
10. At what time is the viewing scheduled?

Listening Part 2 – Monologue

Context: Library orientation talk for new postgraduate students.

Questions 11–20

Answer with a letter or short answer as instructed.

11. What are the library opening hours on weekdays?
 - A. 8 am–10 pm
 - B. 8 am–midnight
 - C. 9 am–8 pm
 - D. 24 hours
12. How many items can postgraduate students borrow at once?
13. For how long is the usual loan period?
14. Where are the silent study areas located?
15. How long does interlibrary loan usually take?
16. How can you access electronic journals remotely?
17. What service offers appointments for thesis structure help?
18. How much is the printing allowance per semester?

19. How much is charged for extra prints?
 20. How can students book a subject librarian consultation?
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Listening Part 3 – Academic Discussion

Context: Three students plan a group research project.

Questions 21–30

Answer in short form.

21. What is Ben's initial research idea?
 22. What alternative idea does Cara propose?
 23. How do they decide to frame their research question? (Write the suggested question.)
 24. Name one data source Ben mentions.
 25. Who will do the GIS mapping?
 26. Who will prepare the literature review?
 27. What task will Anna take on?
 28. How long until the proposal must be submitted?
 29. What additional approval might be required for the survey?
 30. When will they meet again?
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Listening Part 4 – Academic Lecture

Context: Short lecture on neuroplasticity and adult learning.

Questions 31–40

Answer in short form.

31. What are the two types of neuroplasticity mentioned?
32. According to the lecturer, what principle describes the effect of repetition?
33. Name one factor that enhances neuroplasticity besides repetition.
34. Which neurotransmitter is mentioned as mediating reward mechanisms?
35. Do adults show neuroplasticity?
36. Give one practical implication for adult education.
37. Which lifestyle factors support neuroplastic processes?
38. What new intervention is mentioned as promising?
39. What caution does the lecturer give about that intervention?
40. What is the lecturer's overall recommendation for adult learning programs?

Listening Answer Sheet (Template)

Provide a table with Questions 1–40 and spaces for answers (short answer or letter).

READING SECTION

Time: 60 minutes

Questions: 40

There are three passages. Answer all questions.

Reading Passage 1

Urban Beekeeping and Biodiversity

Urban beekeeping has seen a marked rise over the past two decades in cities worldwide. What began as a niche hobby has evolved into a movement with ecological, economic, and educational dimensions. Proponents argue that managed honeybee colonies can contribute to urban biodiversity through pollination services, supporting both cultivated and wild plant species. Critics, however, caution that introducing managed bees into urban ecosystems may pose risks to native pollinator populations and could facilitate disease transmission.

One of the main arguments in favor of urban beekeeping is the demonstrable benefit to pollination. Honeybees (*Apis mellifera*) forage across urban floral resources, visiting community gardens, private balconies, and roadside plantings. This activity can increase fruit set and seed production in certain plant species, especially those dependent on insect pollination. Studies in several European cities have shown correlations between the density of managed hives and increased visitation rates to urban flowers. Furthermore, urban apiaries often function as community hubs, fostering environmental awareness and practical skills among residents. Educational programs tied to beekeeping introduce participants to concepts of ecology, seasonal cycles, and sustainable food production.

Nevertheless, concerns about competition with wild pollinators persist. Urban environments already host diverse native bees, butterflies, and other pollinating insects adapted to fragmented habitats. Managed honeybees can outcompete these native species for floral resources, particularly in areas where nectar and pollen are limited. Additionally, pathogens and parasites such as *Varroa destructor* can be introduced or amplified by dense apiary practices, potentially spilling over into wild populations. Studies comparing floral resource usage have found that honeybees dominate foraging on certain abundant ornamental species, while solitary bees are more specialized on native flora; this dynamic can shift community composition over time.

Another issue relates to the suitability of urban landscapes for sustaining large numbers of managed colonies. Food resource continuity is a concern — many cities exhibit strong seasonal fluctuations in floral abundance, creating periods of scarcity that

necessitate supplemental feeding by beekeepers. Such interventions may mask underlying ecological deficits and provide a false sense of sustainability. Moreover, the spatial clustering of hives on rooftops or in allotments can create local hotspots of competition and disease risk.

Policy responses vary. Some municipalities have developed beekeeping guidelines that limit hive density, require registration, and promote best-practice husbandry to mitigate disease spread. Others emphasize habitat enhancement for native pollinators through planting schemes and conservation of semi-natural spaces. Integrative approaches advocate for small-scale managed beekeeping combined with proactive urban planting to increase resource diversity and availability. Such strategies aim to balance the educational and ecosystem service benefits of managed bees with safeguards for native pollinator conservation.

Research gaps remain. Longitudinal studies are needed to assess long-term impacts of urban apiculture on pollinator community composition and plant reproduction. Additionally, more comparative work across different urban contexts — temperate vs. Mediterranean climates, high-density vs. green-rich cities — would clarify how local conditions mediate outcomes. Ultimately, urban beekeeping exemplifies the challenges of integrating human-managed species into complex ecological networks and highlights the need for evidence-based policy and community engagement.

Questions 1–13

Answer the questions below using information from the passage.

1. According to the passage, what is one benefit of urban beekeeping?
 2. What do critics warn about introducing managed bees into cities?
 3. Which species is given as an example of managed honeybees?
 4. What evidence do proponents cite for pollination benefits?
 5. How do urban apiaries function socially, according to the passage?
 6. What is a major concern about competition mentioned?
 7. Name one pathogen or parasite referenced.
 8. Why might supplemental feeding be necessary?
 9. What policy measures do some municipalities use to mitigate risks?
 10. What do integrative approaches combine?
 11. What research gap is mentioned concerning urban apiculture?
 12. How might local conditions affect outcomes?
 13. According to the final sentence, urban beekeeping highlights the need for what?
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Reading Passage 2

The Economics of Remote Work

The rapid shift to remote work during the early 2020s has prompted economists to reevaluate models of labor productivity, firm costs, and urban geography. Remote work—defined here as performing paid labor primarily from a location outside a traditional office—affects firms and cities in multifaceted ways. On one hand, firms can reduce overhead costs by downsizing office space and shift some expenses to employees. On the other hand, remote work can generate challenges for collaboration, mentoring, and spontaneous innovation that often rely on co-located teams.

Studies measuring productivity under remote arrangements report mixed results. Some research indicates productivity gains due to fewer commuting-related distractions and more flexible scheduling. Other studies suggest declines linked to diminished coordination and reduced access to informal knowledge exchange. Productivity effects also vary by occupation: knowledge-intensive roles that rely on deep, uninterrupted focus may thrive remotely, whereas jobs requiring frequent interactive problem-solving may suffer.

For cities, the aggregate effect of remote work includes reduced demand for central business district (CBD) office rental and changes in commuter flows. Reduced commuter traffic can lower congestion and local pollution, but also impact businesses that depend on office worker footfall, such as cafes, retailers, and public transport revenues. The fiscal implications for city governments are significant: lower office-based employment can reduce business rates receipts and shift tax burdens. Urban real estate markets might adjust, with potential declines in CBD rents and increased demand for housing in suburbs or smaller cities as workers prioritize space and affordability.

Firms adapt through hybrid models—combining periodic in-person meetings with remote work days—to capture benefits of both arrangements. Investment in digital collaboration tools and rethinking management practices have become priorities. Human resources practices evolve too, with remote recruitment widening talent pools across geographies and prompting new considerations for compensation, legal compliance, and employee wellbeing. There are also equity concerns: not all workers can perform their jobs remotely, and disparities in home office quality can exacerbate inequalities.

Policymakers are experimenting with responses. Some cities promote flexible office models and repurpose underused office spaces for residential and cultural uses. Others invest in local amenities to attract remote workers and diversify local economies. There is an ongoing debate about whether remote work will be a transient response to crises or a long-term structural change. The answer likely depends on sectoral composition, technological advances, and policy choices.

Questions 14–26

14. How is remote work defined in the passage?
15. Name one potential firm-level benefit of remote work.

16. Give one challenge for firms caused by remote work.
 17. How does remote work affect productivity according to studies?
 18. Which type of roles may thrive remotely?
 19. What effect does remote work have on CBD office rental demand?
 20. Name one business type that depends on office worker footfall.
 21. What are two consequences for city fiscal revenues?
 22. What model do firms use to combine benefits of remote and in-person work?
 23. How does remote recruitment affect talent pools?
 24. What equity concern is mentioned?
 25. What are two policy responses cities are trying?
 26. What factors will determine whether remote work is transient or permanent?
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Reading Passage 3

The Role of Language in Cognitive Development

Language plays a central role in cognitive development across the lifespan. From early childhood, language acquisition supports the development of memory, executive function, and social cognition. Vygotskian theory posits that language is a tool of thought; inner speech mediates self-regulation and problem-solving. Empirical research links early vocabulary size with later academic outcomes, and interventions targeting language enrichment show improvements in executive control tasks.

Bilingualism has drawn considerable research interest. While earlier views suggested bilingualism might cause cognitive delay, contemporary studies indicate cognitive advantages in areas such as attentional control and task-switching. Bilingual individuals often outperform monolinguals on tasks requiring inhibition of irrelevant information, possibly due to habitual practice in managing multiple linguistic systems. However, effects vary by proficiency levels, age of acquisition, and socio-economic context.

Language also scaffolds cultural learning: narrative practices transmit norms, moral reasoning, and collective memory, which in turn shape cognitive styles. The structure of language — for example, how a language marks tense or evidentiality — can influence habitual attention to certain kinds of information, a claim advanced by linguistic relativity proponents. Yet, strong claims that language determines thought have been tempered by evidence showing both universal cognitive constraints and language-shaped attentional biases.

Educational implications are significant. Early childhood programs emphasizing rich conversational interactions, shared book reading, and oral storytelling foster both language and broader cognitive skills. For multilingual contexts, educational systems should validate and support home languages while teaching the majority language to

promote both cognitive and educational outcomes. There remain open questions about the mechanisms underlying observed bilingual advantages and the long-term developmental trajectories associated with language interventions.

Questions 27–40

27. According to Vygotskian theory, what role does language play?
28. What is the relationship between early vocabulary size and later outcomes?
29. Which cognitive advantages are associated with bilingualism?
30. Why might bilinguals outperform monolinguals on some tasks?
31. What factors influence bilingual effects?
32. How can language shape cultural learning?
33. Give an example in the passage of a linguistic feature that may influence attention.
34. What do proponents of linguistic relativity claim?
35. Name two educational practices that foster language development.
36. What recommendation is given for multilingual educational contexts?
37. What research questions remain about bilingual advantages?
38. How do the authors temper strong claims about language determining thought?
39. According to the passage, what mediates self-regulation?
40. What overall implication for education is stated?

Reading Answer Sheet (Template)

Provide a table with Questions 1–40 and spaces for answers (letters and short answers).

WRITING SECTION

Time: 60 minutes

You must answer both tasks.

Writing Task 1 (Academic)

You should spend about 20 minutes on this task.

The chart below shows the percentage of people aged 18–34 who used three different types of transport (car, bicycle, public transit) to commute to work in City X in 2000, 2010 and 2020.

Write a report for a university lecturer describing the information shown.

Write at least 150 words.

(Insert chart or data in your .doc.)

Writing Task 2 (Academic)

You should spend about 40 minutes on this task.

In many countries, the amount of crime is increasing. What do you think are the causes of this, and what measures can be taken to reduce crime?

Give reasons for your answer and include any relevant examples from your own knowledge or experience.

Write at least 250 words.

SPEAKING SECTION

Time: 11–14 minutes

Format: Three parts – Introduction & Interview, Individual Long Turn, Two-Way Discussion.

Speaking Part 1 – Introduction and Interview (4–5 minutes)

The examiner:

- Introduces themselves and confirms the candidate's identity.
- Asks general questions on familiar topics.

Sample questions

- What is your full name?
 - Can I see your identification?
 - Where are you from?
 - Do you work or are you a student?
 - Let's talk about your hometown. What is it like? What do you like most about it?
 - Let's talk about music. Do you enjoy listening to music? What kind of music do you like?
 - Let's talk about technology. How often do you use the internet? What do you mainly use it for? Do you think the internet is important? Why?
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Speaking Part 2 – Individual Long Turn (3–4 minutes)

The examiner gives you a task card. You have 1 minute to prepare and may make notes. Then you speak for 1–2 minutes. The examiner may ask one or two follow-up questions.

Sample Task Card

Describe a time when you received good advice. You should say:

- who gave you the advice
 - what the advice was
 - why you needed the advice
 - and explain how helpful the advice was.
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Speaking Part 3 – Two-Way Discussion (4–5 minutes)

The examiner and candidate discuss broader issues related to the Part 2 topic.

Sample questions

- What kinds of advice do parents typically give to their children?
 - Do you think young people are more likely to take advice from their friends or their parents? Why?
 - How important is it for people to seek advice when making important decisions?
 - What are some of the qualities of a good advisor?
 - In what situations should people be cautious about taking advice from others?
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ANSWER KEYS (FOR EXAMINERS)

Listening Answer Key

Audio Script — Part 1

Male: Hello, is this Mrs. Carter?

Female: Yes, speaking.

Male: Hi, my name's Daniel Smith. I'm calling about the one-bedroom flat you have available on Willow Street. Is it still on the market?

Female: Yes, it is. Are you looking to move in soon?

Male: As soon as possible, actually. I finish my contract on the 15th of next month. I wanted to ask a few questions — if that's alright.

Female: Of course. What would you like to know?

Male: First, could you tell me the monthly rent and whether utilities are included?

Female: The rent is £850 per month. Gas and water are included, but electricity and council tax are not.

Male: Okay. And is there any deposit required, and how long is the lease?

Female: We ask for a one-month deposit, and the lease is for a minimum of six months.

There's an option to extend.

Male: Great. Is the flat furnished?

Female: It comes partly furnished — a sofa, a table, and the kitchen appliances. You'll need to bring a bed and any other furniture.

Male: That's fine. Is there parking available?

Female: There's on-street parking with a resident permit. There's usually space nearby, but it's not guaranteed.

Male: Right. And how about public transport — are there buses nearby?

Female: Yes, there's a bus stop two minutes' walk away with frequent buses to the city centre.

Male: Perfect. Would it be possible to view the flat this Saturday afternoon?

Female: Saturday at 2 pm is available. Would that work for you?

Male: Yes, Saturday 2 pm works. May I have the address?

Female: Of course. It's 14 Willow Street, flat 2B.

Male: Thanks very much. I'll see you on Saturday.

Female: See you then. Goodbye.

Male: Goodbye.

Part 1 (1–10)

1. Daniel Smith
2. 850 (per month)
3. Gas and water
4. One month's rent / one-month deposit
5. Six months
6. No / partly furnished
7. A bed (and other furniture)
8. No
9. Two minutes' walk
10. 2 pm (Saturday)

Audio Script — Part 2 (approx. 4:00)

Speaker: Welcome to the University Library orientation for new postgraduate students. I'm Maria Gomez, the postgraduate liaison librarian. Today I'll give you a brief overview of the services most relevant to postgraduate study. First, our opening hours are from 8 am to midnight Monday to Friday, and 9 am to 8 pm on weekends. You can access the library building with your student ID card — don't forget to register your card at the front desk if you haven't already. We have a range of study spaces: silent study on the fourth floor, group study rooms on the second floor which can be booked online, and a writing centre on the ground floor that offers appointments for thesis structure and referencing help. For borrowing, postgraduate students can borrow up to

20 items at a time for a loan period of eight weeks, renewable twice unless on reserve. Interlibrary loan services can obtain materials from other institutions; these usually take 7–14 working days. Online resources are extensive: our electronic journals and databases can be accessed remotely by logging in with your university credentials. If you need help with literature searches, our subject librarians provide one-to-one consultations — you can email the subject helpdesk to book a session. Finally, please take note of the printing policy: each student receives a printing allowance of £10 per semester; additional prints are charged at 10p per page. Thank you, and good luck with your studies.

Part 2 (11–20)

11. B (8 am–midnight)
12. 20
13. Eight weeks
14. On the fourth floor
15. 7–14 working days
16. By logging in with university credentials / online login
17. The writing centre
18. 10 (pounds)
19. 10p per page
20. Emailing the subject helpdesk / booking a session

Audio Script — Part 3 (approx. 7:00)

Moderator (Anna): Thanks for coming, everyone. Let's discuss our group research project for the Environmental Policy module. We need to choose a research question and divide tasks. Ben, do you want to start with your ideas?

Ben: Sure. I was thinking about urban green spaces and their impact on local air quality. There's a lot of data on tree cover and particulate matter, and it would allow us to use both field measurements and GIS analysis.

Cara: That sounds promising. I was considering something related to transport emissions, like the effect of congestion charging on traffic emissions in nearby boroughs. It could involve policy analysis and modelling emission changes.

Ben: Both ideas are good. Maybe we could combine elements: look at green spaces' role in mitigating pollution in areas affected by transport emissions.

Anna: Combining them might be complex. We should think about scope and available data. How about framing it as: "To what extent do urban green spaces mitigate traffic-related air pollution in [city district]?" That narrows it down.

Cara: Agreed. For methodology, we could do a literature review, collect air quality data from local monitoring stations, and run a spatial analysis comparing green cover with pollution levels. Also, conduct a short survey of residents about perceived air quality.

Ben: I can handle the GIS mapping and data visualization. Cara, would you be comfortable doing the policy context and literature review?

Cara: Yes, I can do that. Anna, could you coordinate the survey and help with data collection logistics?

Anna: I can. For timeline, we need to submit a proposal in three weeks, and the final

report is due in 12 weeks. We should set internal deadlines: literature review completed in two weeks, data collection by week six, analysis by week nine, and draft by week eleven.

Ben: Sounds tight, but doable if we divide tasks. We should also identify datasets now — I know the city council provides open air quality data and land use maps. We might also use satellite NDVI data for vegetation cover.

Cara: Good point. We also need ethical approval for the survey if it involves human subjects. That process can take up to two weeks.

Anna: Let's assign responsibilities: Ben—data & GIS; Cara—literature & policy; Anna—survey & ethics submission; All—analysis and editing. Any other issues?

Ben: We should consider sampling sites and times for field measurements — weekdays rush hour vs. weekends, and monitor at multiple heights if possible.

Cara: Also budget — we may need sensors or travel costs. We can ask for small funding from the department.

Anna: OK. Let's meet again in five days to confirm datasets and finalize the proposal outline.

Ben & Cara: Agreed.

Anna: Thanks, everyone.

Part 3 (21–30)

21. Urban green spaces and their impact on local air quality

22. Effect of congestion charging on traffic emissions

23. “To what extent do urban green spaces mitigate traffic-related air pollution in a city district?”
(or close equivalent)

24. City council air quality data / land use maps / satellite NDVI data (any one)

25. Ben

26. Cara

27. Coordinating the survey / data collection logistics / ethics submission

28. Three weeks

29. Ethical approval

30. In five days

Audio Script — Part 4 (approx. 10:30)

Lecturer: Today I want to talk about neuroplasticity — the brain's ability to reorganize itself by forming new neural connections throughout life — and its implications for adult learning. Historically, the brain was thought to be relatively fixed after early childhood, but research over the past few decades has shown that structural and functional changes occur in response to experience, even in older adults.

Neuroplasticity can be divided into two types: synaptic plasticity, which involves the strengthening or weakening of synapses based on activity, and structural plasticity, which includes the growth of new dendritic spines and even neurogenesis in certain brain regions. Several factors influence plasticity. First, repetition and practice strengthen neural pathways — the classic “use it or lose it” principle. Second, novelty and challenge promote synaptic growth; learning tasks that are progressively more

complex induce greater reorganization. Third, emotional salience and reward mechanisms, mediated by neurotransmitters like dopamine, enhance consolidation of new skills. Age is a factor but not a limiting one; while younger brains may change more rapidly, adults still show significant plasticity, especially when training is targeted and sustained. Practical implications for adult education include designing spaced and varied practice sessions, incorporating problem-based learning to maintain novelty and challenge, and using feedback and rewards to consolidate learning. Additionally, physical exercise and adequate sleep have been shown to support neuroplastic processes by improving vascularization and supporting memory consolidation during sleep. Finally, recent interventions using non-invasive brain stimulation show promise in enhancing plasticity in combination with cognitive training, although ethical and long-term effects are still under investigation. To conclude, embracing evidence-based practices that align with known mechanisms of plasticity can improve the effectiveness of adult learning programs.

Part 4 (31–40)

31. Synaptic plasticity and structural plasticity
 32. The “use it or lose it” principle
 33. Novelty; challenge; emotional salience; reward mechanisms (any one)
 34. Dopamine
 35. Yes
 36. Designing spaced and varied practice; problem-based learning; using feedback and rewards (any one)
 37. Physical exercise; adequate sleep (either or both)
 38. Non-invasive brain stimulation
 39. Ethical and long-term effects are still under investigation
 40. Use evidence-based practices that align with known mechanisms of plasticity
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Reading Answer Key

Passage 1 (1–13)

1. Contributing to urban biodiversity through pollination services
2. Risks to native pollinator populations and disease transmission
3. *Apis mellifera*
4. Studies showing correlations between hive density and increased visitation to urban flowers
5. They act as community hubs, fostering environmental awareness and practical skills
6. Competition for limited floral resources with native pollinators
7. *Varroa destructor*
8. Seasonal fluctuations in floral abundance creating periods of scarcity
9. Limiting hive density; registration; promoting best-practice husbandry (any)
10. Small-scale managed beekeeping combined with proactive urban planting

11. Need for longitudinal studies on long-term impacts on pollinator communities and plant reproduction
12. Differences between climates and city types (e.g. temperate vs. Mediterranean, high-density vs. green-rich)
13. Evidence-based policy and community engagement

Passage 2 (14–26)

14. Performing paid labour primarily from a location outside a traditional office
15. Reduced overhead costs / smaller office space
16. Challenges for collaboration, mentoring, and spontaneous innovation
17. Mixed results (some gains, some declines)
18. Knowledge-intensive roles needing deep, uninterrupted focus
19. Reduced demand
20. Cafés; retailers; public transport (any one)
21. Lower business rates receipts and shifting tax burdens
22. Hybrid models
23. It widens talent pools across geographies
24. Not all jobs can be done remotely; home office disparities increase inequality
25. Promoting flexible offices; repurposing offices; investing in local amenities (any two)
26. Sectoral composition, technological advances, and policy choices

Passage 3 (27–40)

27. Language is a tool of thought that mediates self-regulation and problem-solving
 28. Larger early vocabularies are linked with better later academic outcomes
 29. Advantages in attentional control and task-switching
 30. Regular practice managing multiple linguistic systems and inhibiting irrelevant information
 31. Proficiency level, age of acquisition, and socio-economic context
 32. Narrative practices transmit norms, morals, and collective memory, shaping cognitive styles
 33. How a language marks tense or evidentiality
 34. That language can influence habitual attention to certain kinds of information
 35. Rich conversational interaction; shared book reading; oral storytelling (any two)
 36. Support home languages while teaching the majority language
 37. Mechanisms behind bilingual advantages and long-term outcomes of language interventions
 38. By pointing to universal cognitive constraints as well as language-shaped biases
 39. Inner speech
 40. Education should foster language to support broader cognitive and academic development
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